India’s objectives with respect to the boundary also resulted in a mismanagement of public expectations and opinion.

Subcontinental Drift: India and Pakistan, 1947–1965

If deteriorating relations with China and the outbreak of war caused a sudden reversal in India’s international ambitions, the rivalry with Pakistan proved more persistent. In part, its origins go back to Partition and the immediate competition over territory, resources, and reputation. But there were surprising strands of cooperation throughout. In December 1947, India and Pakistan signed an agreement to avoid double taxation. In January 1948, India released—at Mahatma Gandhi’s insistence—two-thirds of the share of Reserve Bank cash balances it owed to Pakistan. After a month-long hiatus, the Government of Punjab agreed to release water to Pakistan in 1948, averting drought. Indian currency notes remained legal tender in Pakistan until September 1948, a full year after Partition. All of this occurred even as war was being waged in Jammu and Kashmir. [113] A subsequent crisis over refugees and minority rights was eased by the Nehru–Liaquat Pact of 1950, in which both countries committed to safeguard certain minority rights. [114]

In 1953, Nehru visited Pakistan, but the domestic situation in India limited his options for any real negotiations on resolving outstanding disputes between the two countries. These circumstances included India’s arrests of Jan Sangh leader Syama Prasad Mookerjee (who died in a Kashmiri prison) and of Kashmiri leader Sheikh Abdullah. Nehru found himself caught between Mookerjee’s call for abrogation of autonomy and Abdullah’s calls for independence. India also harboured concerns about US–Pakistan relations, which some in India such as V.K. Krishna Menon seemed to embellish. There were also doubts about the political viability of Pakistan’s leaders. Between the assassination of Liaquat Ali Khan in 1951 and the coup that brought General Ayub Khan to power in 1958, Pakistan was led by a series of short-lived and weak governments. [115]